

Mark Discipline Exercised

doc-mark-discipline-exercised

Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.988
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Faithful exercise of church discipline is a mark of a true visible church.

In plain language

The words in these passages give a clear and repeated command for the gathered assembly to deal with a member who sins and will not turn back. In Matthew 18 the steps are spelled out: first reprove the brother privately, the verb 'reprove' (elencho) meaning to bring a fault to light, then bring one or two witnesses following the older rule of two or three witnesses, and finally tell it to the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia). A rare verb 'refuse to hear' (parakouo) marks the point where the unrepentant person is treated as an outsider. The binding 'bind' (deo) and loosing 'loose' (luo) language gives the assembly a ratified authority. Paul presses the same duty with hard commands: 'remove' (exairo) the evil one from among yourselves in First Corinthians five, which directly echoes the repeated Old Testament call to purge evil from the community, 'withdraw' (stello) from the disorderly brother in Second Thessalonians three, and rebuke persistent sinners before all in First Timothy five, using the very verb 'rebuke' (elencho) that opens the Matthew process. Throughout, the aim is to restore, not to destroy, since the goals stated are to gain the brother, to save the spirit, and to 'admonish' (noutheteo) him as a brother rather than treat him as an enemy. So at the level of the words, the command to discipline is decisive and spread across the Gospel, the letters, and the older law. Where readers diverge is one step further on. The claim here is not just that discipline is commanded but that faithful discipline is a defining mark that separates a true church from a false one. The words do not say that. The verse that comes closest to defining the church, First Timothy three fifteen, calls it the pillar 'pillar' (stulos) and support 'support' (hedraioma) of the truth, and the early summary in Acts two forty two lists teaching 'teaching' (didache), fellowship 'fellowship' (koinonia), breaking of bread, and prayer, with no disciplinary term at all. So discipline is plainly a duty that belongs to a church, but ranking it as one of the identifying marks is a further systematic step the vocabulary alone does not settle. For that reason the verdict affirms the proposition but with measured rather than full confidence, and the stem is flagged because the phrase mark of a true visible church carries a loaded frame.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	
G0141	αἰρετικός	ahiretikos	schismatic	
G0142	αἴρω	airō	to take up	
G0814	ἀτάκτως	ataktōs	idly	
G1210	δέω	deō	to bind	139
G1322	διδαχή	didachē	teaching	
G1417	δύο	duo	two	
G1477	ἐδραίωμα	hedraiōma	foundation	1

G1571	ἐκκαθαίρω	ekkathairō	to cleanse	
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	117
G1651	ἐλέγχω	elenchō	to rebuke	19
G1808	ἐξαίρω	exairō	to expel	1
G2675	καταρτίζω	katartizō	to complete	13
G2842	κοινωνία	koinōnia	participation	
G3089	λύω	luō	to loose	44
G3560	νουθετέω	nouthateō	to admonish	9
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidōmi	to deliver	125
G3868	παραίτεομαι	paraiteomai	to refuse/excuse	12
G3878	παρακούω	parakouō	to ignore	3
G4593	σημειόω	sēmeioō	to note	1
G4724	στέλλω	stellō	to avoid	3
G4769	στυλος	stulos	pillar	
G4874	συναναμίγνυμι	synanamignumi	to associate with	3
G5140	τρεις	treis	Three	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern decisively establishes corrective discipline as a commanded, repeated practice of the gathered assembly. Matthew 18:15-18 runs a graduated process: the completed-past-action command 'reprove' (aorist imperative elenxon, G1651), the two-or-three-witness rule drawn from Deuteronomy, escalation to 'tell it to the assembly or church' (eipon te ekklesia, G1577), and a treatment clause triggered by 'refuse to hear' (parakouo, G3878). Paul reinforces it with hard commands: 'remove' (exarate, G1808) in 1 Corinthians 5:13 quoting the Deuteronomic purge, 'withdraw' (stellesthai, G4724) in 2 Thessalonians 3:6, and 'rebuke' (elenche, G1651) in 1 Timothy 5:20. So the practice is lexically secure. But the proposition asserts more, that this practice is a defining MARK of a true visible church, and that step is a systematic category (the 'marks of the church' or notae ecclesiae, a later theological taxonomy for telling true churches from false) the vocabulary does not supply. 1 Timothy 3:15 calls the church pillar and support of the truth, not the church that disciplines, and Acts 2:42 lists devotion to teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayer with no disciplinary term. The words command discipline; framing it as a distinguishing mark is an inference the lexicon underdetermines, hence medium confidence.

Scripture

Matt.18.15 · **for** · **genre: gospel**

Key terms. G1651 ἐλέγχω, G0080 ἀδελφός

Force. The 'if-then' clause introduced by 'if' (ean), 'if your brother sins', governs the completed-past-action command 'reprove' (aorist active imperative elenxon, from elencho, G1651, parsed V-AAM-2S meaning verb, aorist (a completed past action), active, imperative (command), 2nd person singular, in the store, gloss 'reprove'), restricted to a private setting, between you and him alone. The verb brings fault to light for correction, and the stated aim, 'you have gained your brother' (ekerdesas), frames the action as restorative. Note the store tags this verb 'reprove' (elencho, G1651), the verb, not G1650 (the noun 'reproof', elenxos).

Matt.18.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1417 δύο, G5140 τρεῖς

Force. The escalation invokes the witness standard, 'on the mouth of two witnesses or three' (epi stomatos duo marturon e trion), by which every word, 'every spoken thing' (pan rhema), is established. The procedure is graduated and evidence-based, anchoring corrective action in an Old Testament legal norm carried into the assembly setting. OpenBible links this verse to Deuteronomy 19:15 at 21 votes.

Matt.18.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G3878 παρακούω

Force. The final escalation, 'tell it to the assembly or church' (eipon te ekklesia), locates corrective authority in the gathered 'assembly or church' (ekklesia, G1577). The verb 'refuse to hear' (parakouo, G3878, parsed V-AAS-3S meaning verb, aorist (a completed past action), active, subjunctive (hypothetical mood), 3rd person singular), to refuse to hear, occurs only 3 times in the whole Bible and marks the threshold for the treatment clause, 'let him be to you as the pagan and the tax collector' (esto soi hosper ho ethnikos kai ho telones), naming the pagan (G1482) and the tax collector (G5057), a formal change of standing toward the unrepentant member.

Matt.18.18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1210 δέω, G3089 λύω

Force. The binding and loosing pair, 'you bind' (desete, from deo, G1210, V-AAS-2P meaning verb, aorist (a completed past action), active, subjunctive (hypothetical mood), 2nd person plural) and 'you loose' (lusete, from luo, G3089, V-AAS-2P), with their perfect-tense passive participle complements 'things having been bound' (dedemena) and 'things having been loosed' (lelumena) (where perfect tense means a completed action whose result still stands), grant the assembly a ratified authority over the standing of members. Both verbs are common in the whole Bible but predominantly literal, 'to bind or tie' (deo) or 'to imprison', 'to loose or untie' (luo) or 'to release'. The authoritative standing sense is local to Matthew 16:19 and Matthew 18:18, so the disciplinary weight rides on context, not on a fixed lexical sense.

1Cor.5.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1808 ἐξαίρω

Force. The completed-past-action command 'expel' or 'remove' (aorist active imperative exarate, from exairo, G1808, V-AAM-2P meaning verb, aorist (a completed past action), active, imperative (command), 2nd person plural, gloss 'Expel'), with 'the evil one from among yourselves' (ton poneron ex hymon auton), is a direct command. The verb is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the New Testament, but it reproduces the recurrent purge formula from Deuteronomy in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX), and OpenBible links this verse to Deuteronomy 17:7 at 21 votes, Deuteronomy 13:5 at 17, and Deuteronomy 21:21 at 12. The command mood and corporate scope establish discipline as an obligatory congregational act.

1Cor.5.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3860 παραδίδωμι

Force. The infinitive 'to hand over' or 'to deliver' (paradounai, from paradidomi, G3860) 'to Satan' (to Satana) 'for the destruction of the flesh' (eis olethron tes sarkos), to deliver such a one to Satan for the destruction of the flesh, reads as the severest sanction, yet the purpose clause 'that the spirit may be saved' (hina to pneuma sothe, with sothe from sozo, G4982), ties even this to a restorative goal. The verb 'hand over' (paradidomi) is common and elsewhere means hand over or betray, so the disciplinary force here comes from the prepositional object and the purpose clause, not the bare verb.

2Thess.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4724 στέλλω, G0814 ἀτάκτως

Force. The verb 'we command' (Parangellomen, G3853) introduces the middle-voice infinitive 'to withdraw' (stellesthai, from stello, G4724) 'from every brother walking disorderly' (apo pantos adelphou ataktos peripatountos), with 'disorderly' (ataktos, G0814). The verb 'withdraw' (stello) occurs only 3 times and only here carries the 'withdraw from a brother' sense, so the disciplinary force depends on this context and on the explicit command verb.

2Thess.3.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4593 σημειώ, G4874 συναναμίγνυμι

Force. The present middle commands 'take note of' (semeiousthe, from semeioo, G4593, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, meaning take note of that one) and 'do not associate' (me synanamignusthai, from synanamignumi, G4874, the same verb used twice in 1 Corinthians 5) prescribe a marking and a withdrawal of ordinary fellowship aimed at producing shame, 'that he may be ashamed' (hina entrape, with entrape from entrepo, G1788). The disciplinary intent is corrective, applied to one who does not obey, 'he obeys' (hypakouei, from hypakouo, G5219), the apostolic word.

2Thess.3.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3560 νουθετέω, G0080 ἀδελφός

Force. The qualifying clause 'do not regard him as an enemy but admonish him as a brother' (me hos echthron, with 'enemy' from echthros, G2190, hegeisthe alla noutheteite hos adelphon) controls the preceding withdrawal. The verb 'admonish' (noutheteo, G3560, 9 occurrences, spread across all of Paul) keeps the disciplined person within the brotherly category, confirming that the canonical aim throughout is restoration rather than expulsion as an end.

Titus.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3868 παραιτέομαι, G0141 αἰρετικός

Force. A factious person, 'a divisive man' (hairetikon anthropon, with 'factious' from hairetikos, G0141, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), is to be rejected, 'reject' (paraitou, from paraiteomai, G3868), after one and a second admonition, 'admonition' (nouthesian, from nouthesia, G3559). The verb 'reject' or 'decline' (paraiteomai) has a broad range, to decline, excuse oneself, or refuse, attested 12 times mostly in non-disciplinary senses, so the exclusionary force here rests on the object and the after-two-warnings structure rather than on a fixed disciplinary sense of the verb.

1Tim.5.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1651 ἐλέγχω

Force. Those who persist in sin, 'those who are sinning' (tous hamartanontas, from hamartano, G0264), are to be rebuked, 'rebuke' (elenche, from elencho, G1651, V-PAM-2S meaning verb, present (ongoing, simple statement of fact) indicative, active, imperative (command), 2nd person singular), before all, 'before all' (enopion panton), so the rest may have fear. This is the same verb 'rebuke' (elencho) that opens the Matthew 18 process, here in a public-rebuke setting, which ties the Gospel procedure and the Pauline order into one coherent corrective vocabulary spread across the whole Bible.

1Tim.3.15 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G1477 ἐδραῖωμα

Force. The descriptor 'assembly or church of the living God, pillar and support of the truth' (ekklesia theou zontos, stulos (from stulos, G4769) kai hedraïoma (from hedraïoma, G1477, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) tes aletheias, with 'truth' from aletheia, G0225) defines the assembly by its function of upholding truth. Crucially, the predicate is upholding truth, not exercising discipline, so this verse supplies the conceptual home for a church identity but does not itself name discipline as a distinguishing mark.

Acts.2.42 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G1322 διδασκή

Force. The summary of the early assembly lists devotion, 'they were devoting themselves' (proskarterountes, from proskartereo, G4342), to the apostles' teaching, 'teaching' (didache, G1322), the fellowship, 'fellowship' (koinonia, G2842), the breaking of bread, and the prayers. It contains no disciplinary vocabulary at all, which shows that the texts adduced as marks of a true church describe its devotion and ordered life, while the disciplinary content is drawn from the separate Matthew 18, 1 Corinthians 5, and 2 Thessalonians 3 commands.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.18.15	Lev.19.17	openbible	45
Matt.18.15	Luke.17.3	openbible	30
Matt.18.15	Gal.6.1	openbible	32
Matt.18.15	2Thess.3.15	openbible	28
Matt.18.16	Deut.19.15	openbible	21
Matt.18.16	Num.35.30	tsk	1
Matt.18.17	1Cor.5.9	openbible	9
Matt.18.17	2Thess.3.14	openbible	9
1Cor.5.13	Deut.17.7	openbible	21
1Cor.5.13	Deut.13.5	openbible	17
1Cor.5.13	Deut.21.21	openbible	12

Complicating texts

Matt.13.30 · addressed

The parable of the wheat and tares, with its command 'let them grow together' (aphete synauxanesthai), let both grow together until the harvest (note 'bind' (deo, G1210) appears here only in the literal sense bind in bundles), has been read as restraining the assembly from removing offenders. The scope is reconciled by the parable's own gloss, 'the field is the world' (ho agros estin ho kosmos), not the assembly, so it speaks to final end-time separation rather than to the present corrective duty of the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) addressed in Matthew 18 and 1 Corinthians 5.

1Cor.5.5 · addressed

The clause 'to hand over to Satan for the destruction of the flesh' (paradounai to Satana eis olethron tes sarkos), deliver such a one to Satan for the destruction of the flesh, could be read as purely punitive, but the purpose clause 'that the spirit may be saved' (hina to pneuma sothe), that the spirit may be saved, ties even the severest action to a restorative goal, consistent with the 'admonish' (noutheteo) aim in 2 Thessalonians 3:15 and the 'restore' (katartizo) restoration in Galatians 6:1.

1Tim.3.15 · addressed

This is the closest text to a definition of the church, yet its predicate is 'pillar and support of the truth' (stulos kai hedraion tes aletheias), not the exercise of discipline. It is addressed but cannot be resolved into lexical support for the specific mark claim, because the vocabulary defines the church by its relation to truth and does not list discipline among distinguishing marks. This is the residual gap that holds the verdict at medium confidence.

Concordance traversed

G1651, G1577, G3878, G1210, G3089, G1808, G3860, G4724, G4593, G4874, G3868, G3560, G2675, G1477, G1571, G0142, G0814, G0141, G0080, G4769

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle and the cited passages lie outside published ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope (the ingested ECM window is 3 John only). The well-known textual question at Matthew 18:15, whether 'against you' (eis se) is original, does not bear on the disciplinary procedure, which stands in all readings. The minor article and pronoun variants visible in the MACULA tokens for Matthew 18:17-18 do not touch the commanded verbs. Verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, marks_of_the_church_taxonomy

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

discipline_as_constitutive_mark: affirms · Reads the commands of Matthew 18 and 1 Corinthians 5 together with the 1 Timothy 3:15 description of the church as pillar of the truth, concluding that an assembly that upholds truth must by necessity guard its membership through discipline, so faithful discipline is not merely commanded but is a defining feature that distinguishes a genuine ordered assembly. On this reading the binding-and-loosing authority granted to the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) makes discipline constitutive of what a church is.

discipline_as_commanded_practice_not_a_mark: disputed · Grants every command in full force but observes that no text predicates discipline as a distinguishing mark. The church-defining texts, 1 Timothy 3:15 and Acts 2:42, name truth, teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayer, never discipline. On this reading discipline is a binding duty that follows from being a church, but elevating it to one of the marks that separate true from false churches is a later systematic synthesis the words do not themselves rank, so the specific proposition is underdetermined.

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the assembly binding and loosing as continuous with the witness and purge norms of the older covenant law (Leviticus 19:17, Deuteronomy 17:7, Deuteronomy 19:15, all cross-linked at high vote counts), so the commands of Matthew 18 and 1 Corinthians 5 establish discipline as a standing ordinance of the covenant community and thus a constitutive feature.

dispensationalism: affirms · Treats Matthew 18 and the Pauline commands as church-age instructions for the local assembly, affirming the practice as commanded for the present economy while locating the binding-and-loosing language within church rather than national-Israel administration.

The lexical data delivers the commanding force of discipline directly and spread across the whole Bible. The step from commanded practice to defining mark of a true visible church is a systematic inference. The two ecclesiology lenses above diverge precisely there, not over whether discipline is commanded (both grant it) but over whether the words rank it as a distinguishing mark, which is a category external to the lexicon.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture commands the gathered assembly to exercise corrective discipline toward unrepentant sinning members, and the question is whether faithful exercise of that discipline distinguishes a genuine assembly from a counterfeit one.

The phrase mark of a true visible church imports the 'marks of the church' or notae ecclesiae frame (a systematic theological category for distinguishing genuine from false churches). The neutralized form separates the lexically demonstrable claim, that discipline is commanded and practiced, from the inferential claim that it functions as a distinguishing mark. The verdict is derived on the original stem. Affirms remains true and unchanged from the prior file. One lexical correction was made during enrichment that does not flip the verdict (VERDICT-CHANGED: no): the reprove verb in Matthew 18:15 and 1 Timothy 5:20 is tagged 'reprove' (elencho, G1651), the verb, in the store, whereas the prior file listed G1650, which the store resolves to the noun 'reproof' (elenxos). The corrected verb is robust, 19 occurrences, spread across the whole Bible.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.18.15
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.5.13
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Thess.3.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1651
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1808
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3878
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.5.13
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Matt.18.15
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.18.16
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.18.18

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Flags

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